AFFINITY TANKER WEEKLY

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Crude Tanker Comments

VLCCs have softened throughout the week as limited enquiry and increasingly competitive Suezmax alternatives have tempered owners' expectations. East of Suez, there was a small but noticeable increase in activity in an area with a tight prompt tonnage list. However, this proved insufficient to prevent rates from easing, with a Fujairah-East fixture rumoured to be on subs at WS 565 and TD34 now sitting at WS 545.

The Atlantic saw sharper declines as cheaper Suezmax cover drew business away from VLCCs, with Brazil-East falling from WS 607 on Monday to WS 572 on Wednesday and WAFR-East falling to WS 500 today. Tighter prompt tonnage could offer some support East of Suez if enquiry continues, while Atlantic VLCCs face a tougher task securing cover as long as smaller tanker classes remain cheaper.

After a couple of weeks of weak levels of Suezmax activity and an ever-growing tonnage list, rates were always set to correct downwards, but the speed at which they have dropped has been stark. In WAFR, rates have softened to WS 400 last done, down from approximately WS 700 at the start of the week.

CPC rates have also seen a sharp decline, with WS 725 on subs following a very brief return to the conference rate of WS 900 owing to AWRP artificially inflating rates. The US Gulf has also seen a steep correction downwards, with WS 295 now on subs for TA, a decrease from theoretical levels of WS 550, as witnessed in one deal! Rates out of Guyana, meanwhile, have remained untested this week, but the last done of WS 625 does not look repeatable, and it is likely that it will follow the rest of the Atlantic down the slide.

East of Suez, things have remained quiet as charterers continue to favour VLCCs; one cargo did emerge, however, with Fujairah-East now paying at WS 535. But given the plethora of tonnage out East, one can expect a long caravan of ships ballasting west to have emerged come Monday morning.

The Mediterranean Aframax market weakened this week. Monday opened quietly after a subdued close last Friday, with a long position list and weak sentiment encouraging charterers to test rates lower. By Tuesday, they had capitalised on the tonnage supply to push levels down, and Wednesday brought lacklustre activity with all western markets under pressure. Thursday saw rates slide in 100-point steps on every fixture, leaving charterers firmly in control and further drops still expected. TD19 ends the week at WS 285.

It was a similar story in the North Sea, where Aframax rates softened through the week as sharp corrections in surrounding markets made their way into that one. On Monday, lengthy local lists left charterers with the advantage, and Tuesday saw charterers keep enquiries close and conduct off-market fixing. Owners spent Wednesday digesting a sharp correction while charterers pressed for less. By Thursday, with Med and USG rates falling and the entire Atlantic Basin under pressure, TD7 looked overpriced, and further downside is expected. The rate is WS 325 at the time of writing.

Product Tanker Comments

The AG LR2 market has taken some losses this week. Once again, the throughput of CPP to the market depends largely on one Gulf State oil company, and there has been good activity from this area. But with so few chartering conduits to shipowners, there were freight discounts off the back of a positions list longer than what the market has been used to through summer and autumn. 75,000 T naphtha was agreed last week at WS 450, but this week the rate was adjusted sharply down to WS 400. Westbound deliveries were looking poised to go under USD 10 Mn, and it has happened, with USD 9 Mn on subs for Oman-UK Cont via Bab-el-Mandeb. EAFR was also re-adjusted down from 90 x WS 485, with 90 x WS 400 on subs at this time of writing.

The Red Sea has been quieter, but with the crumbling X-Med Afra market in play, next done will likely be much below the agreements above USD 10 Mn made over recent weeks. Some stems from the firmer MR market are expected to build up into the LR2 segment, so prospects could well turn, and one must not forget that very good money is still being made despite the fall from the recent stratospheric levels.

AG LR1s have faced a downward trend this week, as limited fresh cargoes – public or off-market – have allowed tonnage to build at the front end. Rates have slipped across the board when tested, and rumours of further falls are circulating. TC5 equivalent has been agreed at WS 470 publicly, but there are rumours of WS 450, though they are yet to be substantiated. Westbound rates had last been agreed at USD 8.65 Mn via Suez, but the market has softened more since then; current levels are estimated to sit between USD 7 Mn and USD 7.5 Mn via Suez. There has been much news about the US midterm elections, and speculation about a resurgence of strikes abounds. These would obviously have a knock-on effect on freight levels and general shipping movements, as some owners would retract from Fujairah and Sohar loadings, so any escalations in the region should be monitored.

Med MRs had a quiet, dull week. Much of what has been worked has been kept off-market, and with Handysizes testing down, the expectation is that MR levels are following suit on a pro-rata basis. The limited Handysize activity – especially when compared with recent weeks – has allowed tonnage to build up, particularly because MRs have been preferred for what business there is. Rates have come under pressure; the latest figure of WS 420 represents a 10-point drop. Activity is expected to pick back up toward the back end of next week, so levels should not come off too far. Sentiment is quiet to soft for now, but it would not take much for a turnaround here.

NWE MRs had a slow week, and levels have remained under pressure. Tonnage has continued to build, and rates have softened across the board, with ARA-WAFR now on subs at WS 290 and TC2 freighting at WS 190. Sentiment remains soft, and if activity continues at its current pace, the floor is yet to be found. The week was also quiet for NWE Handies, with levels correcting down from WS 505 to WS 445. Still, with the MRs continuing to soften, Handy rates remain under downward pressure. Without fresh cargoes, Handy and MR owners are increasingly competing for the limited X-UKC and Med stems available. The next fresh test for X-UKC will likely be around WS 400, with the floor not yet found given the current lack of activity and replenishing tonnage.

	BDTI	BCTI
	5480	2636
Δ W-O-W	↓Softer	↓Softer

BDA

(USD/LDT)	TKR/LRG	TKR/MED	TKR/SML
This week	518.2	526.7	532.2
Δ W-O-W	10.9	11.1	13.3

BALTIC TCE DIRTY

	Route	Qty	$ / Day	W-O-W
TD3C	ME Gulf / China	270,000	1,285,922	↓Softer
TD7	UKC / UKC	80,000	219,773	↓Softer
TD15	WAF / China	260,000	493,106	↓Softer
TD19	Med / Med	80,000	92,619	↓Softer
TD20	WAF / Cont	130,000	207,106	↓Softer
TD22	USG / China	270,000	415,390	↓Softer
TD25	USG / Cont	70,000	83,176	↓Softer
TD26	EC Mex / USG	70,000	97,129	↓Softer
TD27	Guyana / UKC	130,000	186,278	↓Softer

BALTIC TCE CLEAN

	Route	Qty	$ / Day	W-O-W
TC1	ME Gulf / Japan	75,000	294,560	↑Firmer
TC2	Cont / USAC	37,000	12,340	↓Softer
TC5	ME Gulf / Japan	55,000	212,207	↑Firmer
TC6	Algeria / EU Med	30,000	80,259	↓Softer
TC7	Sing. / ECA	30,000	66,831	↓Softer
TC8	ME Gulf / UKC	65,000	223,790	↓Softer
TC14	USG / UKC	38,000	62,921	↓Softer
TC17	ME Gulf / EAFR	35,000	114,811	↑Firmer
TC20	ME Gulf / UKC	90,000	292,594	↓Softer
TC21	USG / Caribs	38,000	63,976	↓Softer

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